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Mysteries of Immortal Puppet Master

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XIANGGONG
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Chapter 1: Hanging-Hair Traveler^[^1]

In the Ning Clan^[^2]'s council hall.

Bright light radiated from the spirit lamp. The Ning Clan's patriarch, junior patriarch, and elders had all assembled.

Several jade slips passed among them; these jade slips contained records of the Ning Clan's most recent clan examination.

Stroking the jade slip in his hand, the patriarch's eyes closed lightly, and the scenes inside the jade slip replayed continuously in his sea of consciousness.

This year, unlike previous years, he mainly focused on the subject of mechanical arts.

The contents of the Ning Clan's mechanical arts exam had changed this year, to a test of puppet manipulation. The juniors of the clan infused their magical power into the puppets through wire threads.

Urged along by the combination of divine intent^[^3] and magical power^[^4], the puppets were made to perform various actions. However, even the most skilled juniors could only make their puppets walk a bit, flip over, and roll around.

Overall, the situation was disastrous.

Slowly opening his eyes, the patriarch withdrew his consciousness from the jade slip and placed it back on the table in front of him.

"It looks like there are no seeds of mechanical arts masters among our younger generation." The Ning Clan patriarch sighed.

Feeling pressure, the academy elder quickly spoke up: “Patriarch, fellow elders, our Ning Clan’s expertise lies in talismans. Among the hundred arts of cultivation, mechanical arts is only a minor discipline. Our clan has a weak foundation in this regard, and the academy’s mechanical arts teachers have little accomplishments. How could we possibly cultivate a genius of mechanical arts?”

The Ning Clan patriarch comforted, “Don’t worry, I’m not blaming you. But the Lava Immortal Palace that Three Schools Supreme Sage^[^5] buried in Fire Persimmon Mountain to suppress its eruptions is an immortal city of mechanisms. If we want to obtain the immortal treasures and the mechanical arts inheritance within the Lava Immortal Palace, we need a mechanical arts master to lead the way.

“Our Ning Clan only discovered the Lava Immortal Palace this year. The other two clans, along with the city lord’s side, have known about it for a long time already. Unlike us, they’ve had plenty of time to secretly cultivate talented mechanical arts masters.

“We’re late, too late. Our only chance of competing is by spending money to recruit outsiders as our honored guests.”

The Ning Clan patriarch took out a jade slip and said, “Listed here are the most famous mechanical arts masters in and around Fire Persimmon Immortal City. Please take a look.”

Once all the elders had read the jade slip, the Ning Clan patriarch spoke up again: “We must contact all these mechanical arts masters and get them to join us. Especially that Hanging-Hair Traveler! As one of the premiere mechanical arts masters in Fire Persimmon Immortal City, he is a target we absolutely must win over.”

The junior patriarch said, “Hanging-Hair Traveler’s identity is mysterious, and he never appears in public. His mechanical constructs sell well, but they’re only sold once a month through the black market.

“And the black market is controlled by Sun Lingtong^[6], an outer disciple of the Spaceless Sect^[7]. Thus, getting close to Hanging-Hair Traveler truly isn’t easy.”

The Ning Clan patriarch frowned. “Xiaoren, I don’t want to hear about your problems, I want solutions.”

Cold sweat broke out on the junior patriarch Ning Xiaoren’s^[8] forehead, and he quickly said, “Yes, father. I have already sent someone to contact him, and we will see results soon!”

The Ning Clan patriarch stroked his beard. “Good. Then I’ll await your success.”

. . .

After the meeting, the Ning Clan’s junior patriarch immediately summoned his subordinate, Ning Ze^[9].

“Ning Ze, the only reason you’re sitting in the seat of the Ning Clan’s procurement manager right now is because of me. I’ve tasked you with contacting Hanging-Hair Traveler, but you have yet to make any progress. Just what do you think you’re doing?” The junior patriarch scolded.

Ning Ze was a middle-aged man with a bitter look on his face. If possible, he would rather have nothing to do with this task.

“Junior patriarch, I’ve failed to live up to your expectations. I truly deserve to die.

“But that Hanging-Hair Traveler is really difficult to communicate with! While purchasing his Up-Down As-You-Wish Cables^[^10] in the black market, I’ve tried to talk to him many times, but he always remains unmoved and refuses to speak of anything other than the transaction at hand.

“Hanging-Hair Traveler is too mysterious. I’ve exhausted every means to figure out his true identity, but only ended up angering the master of the black market, Sun Lingtong. Not only did I end up losing a lot of men, I was even scammed out of a large number of spirit stones...”

“Enough!” The junior patriarch interrupted with an unhappy look on his face. “Getting scammed is shameful enough. Don’t tell me you still want the clan to reimburse you?

“Listen up. This time, the clan is purchasing eighty Up-Down As-You-Wish Cables. Go take care of it.”

Ning Ze was surprised, "Eighty? So many?!"

The junior patriarch said, “This is a big business deal, so do your best. You’ve talked to Hanging-Hair Traveler so many times, but still haven’t gotten any closer to him.

“Ning Ze, your performance is really making me doubt your abilities.”

Feeling pressured, Ning Ze vowed to do his utmost.

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Ning Ze arrived at the southeast district of Fire Persimmon Immortal City.

This district was a place where good and bad mixed together. Theft was rampant here, and law and order was at its weakest.

At the same time, this was also where the black market was located.

Coming to one of the entrances to the black market, Ning Ze pulled out a token. An evil-looking cultivator glanced at him and checked the token carefully, then coldly said, "Follow me."

The evil-looking cultivator led Ning Ze into the hut behind him and lifted the floor, revealing an underground passageway. He and Ning Ze entered the passage, and after many twists and turns, finally came out in an underground market.

Glancing around, Ning Ze saw his target.

"Sir Hanging-Hair Traveler, we meet again." Ning Ze put a warm smile on his face as he walked over to Hanging-Hair Traveler.

Hanging-Hair Traveler was an old man with a severely hunched back, leaning on a cane with his whole body bent like a shrimp. His face was haggard, with dark eye bags and wrinkles deep enough to catch mosquitoes. Messy, long black hair hung down from his head, covering his shoulders and reaching down to his feet like a cloak of darkness.

Standing behind his cart, Hanging-Hair Traveler glanced at Ning Ze lightly without saying a word.

Hanging-Hair Traveler's attitude was always like this. Ning Ze couldn't do anything, but rage built up in his heart.

He was a member of the great Ning Clan, but this Hanging-Hair Traveler dared not give him face!

However, the Ning Clan's junior patriarch was very insistent on pulling Hanging-Hair Traveler to their side. Thus, despite his indignation, Ning Ze could only smile and say, "Sir Hanging-Hair Traveler, I've brought big business for you this time.

"A full eighty Up-Down As-You-Wish Cables!

"Look, for such a huge transaction, how about you give a bit of a discount?

"I'm an old customer of yours, and if this deal goes well, there will be more deals like this in the future. Isn't it too heartless of you to always charge 200 spirit stones for each cable?"

Hanging-Hair Traveler nodded slightly and said in his hoarse voice, "You're right.

"In that case, it'll be 250 spirit stones per cable."

Ning Ze froze for a moment, then laughed, "Sir Hanging-Hair Traveler, don't joke around. What kind of discount is that?"

But Hanging-Hair Traveler snorted, "Every word of nonsense is another 50 spirit stones."

Ning Ze was stunned.

Fury continued bubbling within him, and he wanted nothing more than to slap the old man in front of him straight into the ground. But in the end, he forced down his anger and said in a sullen voice, "Okay, we'll go with your price!

“But my clan would like to add some modifications to match our unique skills. As for the specifics...”

Hanging-Hair Traveler interrupted forcefully, “No modifications. Buy or get out.”

Ning Ze choked.

After taking a deep breath, he nodded with a wry smile and agreed to the deal.

Hanging-Hair Traveler didn’t move, but several small mechanical puppets popped out from the roof of the mechanical cart in front of him.

These puppets were all manipulated by wire threads, but they looked shockingly realistic as they laughed and babbled. They rolled, jumped, and even pushed each other playfully as they moved to open the round cover inside the mechanical cart.

Then, they entered the hole one by one and dragged out Up-Down As-You-Wish Cables like emerging from a nest of pythons.

Every time he saw this scene, Ning Ze couldn’t help but sigh in amazement.

This subtle manipulation ability was so skilled that the puppets seemed to come alive.

If a junior of the Ning Clan had even one percent of this skill, their mechanical arts score in the exam would be top of the class!

But mechanical arts is ranked at the bottom of the hundred arts of cultivation, and has many weaknesses. The most obvious weakness is their manipulation method!

Just look at these puppets. As long as their wires are severed, they'll be rendered immobile in an instant.

After handing over the spirit stones, Ning Ze left the black market along with the Up-Down As-You-Wish Cables. Only then did he reveal a hint of viciousness and anger.

"Hanging-Hair Traveler! You should be honored that I've spoken so nicely to you all this time.

"Now, I've invited the Huang Family Ghost Trio and even prepared a special 'gift' for you!

"Since you dare refuse my toast, it's time for you to drink a forfeit."

In his desperation, Ning Ze had decided to take a big risk.

His plan was very simple: He would get the Huang Family Ghost Trio to deal with Hanging-Hair Traveler, then come out and resolve the situation to establish goodwill. If Hanging-Hair Traveler ended up seriously injured, Ning Ze wouldn't rule out use of force either.

In any case, his first priority was to break the stalemate and complete his own task. As for any later issues, those would have to be handled by other Ning Clan members.

After the black market closed, Hanging-Hair Traveler carried his proceeds and walked into a dark alley.

Suddenly...

Soul-Suppressing Talisman!

With the activation of a talisman, the surroundings pace was immediately sealed, and Hanging-Hair Traveler halted on the spot.

"Heeheehee..."

Light laughter echoed out, and three little ghosts attacked Hanging-Hair Traveler from his left.

Hanging-Hair Traveler was silent as a stone until the little ghosts drew near. Then, he suddenly shook his body.

Several mechanical birds immediately shot out.

Mechanical construct - Silent Thunderbird!

Flashes of light illuminated the darkness. Lightning crackled, but there was no sound.

In just an instant, the Silent Thunderbirds eradicated the three little ghosts.

“How is this possible?”

“We used the Soul-Suppressing Talisman! How could he still be able to use his divine sense and control those mechanical puppets?!”

“Strange, those are clearly mechanical puppets, but I didn’t see him using any wires at all.”

“It doesn’t matter. Let’s all go together!”

The Huang Family Ghost Trio jumped out and moved simultaneously, each displaying various methods to attack Hanging-Hair Traveler.

In an instant, dozens of ghosts appeared. Malicious ghosts filled the surroundings, looking fierce and sinister with their fangs and claws bared.

Hanging-Hair Traveler remained steady as a mountain. His messy black hair that reached his feet suddenly twisted together to form long whips.

These long black whips danced like dragons or snakes, but gave rise to no wind. Their silent movements were filled with terrifying killing

intent.

Mechanical construct - Hanging-Hair Hooked Death Whips!

These whips were extremely ferocious, seemingly capable of swallowing everything in their path. Wherever they swiped, fierce ghosts disappeared from existence.

Eyes flickering with ferocity, the Huang Family Ghost Trio were about to attack.

But at that moment, in Hanging-Hair Traveler's sea of consciousness...

There was a magical seal stamp, imposing like a mountain, like both a Buddha and a demon, that suddenly flashed with wondrous light.

Magic treasure - Buddha Heart Demon Seal!

The trio simultaneously stilled, revealing fatal openings. They recovered in an instant and retreated in a panic, but it was already too late.

Two screams rang out. Two ghosts were dead.

The leader of the trio was immediately furious, and he worked his Foundation Establishment dantian at full strength to counterattack Hanging-Hair Traveler.

A magical dagger carrying his deep grudge shot out as fast lightning, instantly striking Hanging-Hair Traveler in the middle of the forehead.

Ding.

A crisp sound of metal striking metal rang out.

The trio leader was stunned for a moment, full of disbelief.

Swoosh!

An instant later, dozens of Hanging-Hair Hooked Death Whips pierced his body from every direction.

The leader's eyes widened. Pierced by numerous whips, his body hung in the air as blood spurted out from his wounds and splashed all over the alley. However, the dark of night seemed to swallow up everything.

Sensing the commotion, a nearby cultivator came over to the alley to check, wondering aloud, "What happened?"

In the alley, there were neither any corpses nor a single drop of blood...

After waiting for so long with no news, Ning Ze was feeling cold both inside and out.

"Why is there no news? It's been so long, they should have succeeded.

"Hanging-Hair Traveler is in the Foundation Establishment stage, and the Huang Family Ghost Trio are also in Foundation Establishment. Even though their battle prowess is suppressed inside the immortal city, it's three against one! There's no reason they would fail.

"I gave them a Soul-Suppressing Talisman and the Verdant Blade Mantis spirit pet that can sever wires. They should have an overwhelming advantage against any mechanical arts master!

"I'll wait a little longer."

Unfortunately, the news he was waiting for would never come.

. . .

Hanging-Hair Traveler walked along an underground secret passage.

Three Hanging-Hair Hooked Death Whips were raised up behind him, each one piercing the corpse of a cultivator. As he walked, he cast a terrifying, eerie shadow on the wall of the passage.

Soon, a red light appeared up ahead, and the temperature rose rapidly.

As Hanging-Hair Traveler turned the corner, a large furnace appeared in front of him. Opening the furnace door, he tossed the three corpses inside with swift and practiced movements.

Then, he shut the furnace door and walked over to a side storage room, taking out several jin^[^11] of fire essence and tossing them inside.

After many years of accumulation, the fire essence in the storage room had piled up into a small mountain.

“Just ten jin left.”

Hanging-Hair Traveler then went to the teleportation room and activated the teleportation formation.

An instant later, he returned to his underground workshop, and his body began to change.

That strange black hair hanging down to the ground rapidly retracted, and his hunched figure gradually straightened out. Light and shadow flickered on the body of the old man beneath the black robe, slowly revealing “his” true appearance:

A silver-gray suit of mechanical armor.

Wondrous light flowed faintly across the surface of the armor, illuminating talisman runes and formation patterns all over. There was also a new scar on the armor’s helmet – a souvenir from the trio leader’s dying blow.

The chest, abdomen, and leg plates of the armor opened up, and a young man walked out from within.

This young man had a fair complexion, clear eyes, and a calm and peaceful temperament.

The armor's name was Iron Will Gray Armor^[^12].

As for the young man, he was Ning Zhuo^[^13].

Notes:

[^1]: *Hanging-Hair Traveler* – 垂髫客 – Also known in various translations as “Chui Tiao Ke” or “Young Puppet Master”. 垂 means “hanging down”, and 髫 seems to refer to the hair on children? 垂髫 is used in the “Hanging-Hair Hooked Death Whips”, and the narrative talks about how his hair hangs down to his feet, so I decided to go with “Hanging Hair”. But it also might carry implications of youth and childhood.

[^2]: *Ning Clan* – 宁家 – Ning is a surname that can mean “peaceful” or “tranquil”.

[^3]: *divine intent* – 神念 – Basically just the power of thought. Evolves into divine sense (神识).

[^4]: *magical power* – 法力 – This is not spirit power (灵力) or spirit energy (灵气). Those exist in this novel, but are different things. Magical power is used to control magic artifacts (法器) and magic treasures (法宝), and also to cast spells (法术, literally “magic arts”).

[^5]: *Three Schools Supreme Sage* – 三宗上人 – Three Schools refers to Daoism, Buddhism, and the demonic way. Usually, 宗 is “Sect”, but he's not in charge of three cultivation sects or anything as far as I know, so I went with “School” as in “school of thought”. 上人 literally means something like “superior person”, but basically refers to someone of great wisdom and virtue (and, since this is xianxia, power).

[^6]: *Sun Lingtong* – 孙灵瞳 – Sun is a surname, same as in Sun Wukong. Lingtong means “spirit eyes”.

[^7]: *Spaceless Sect* – 不空門 – 不 is a negation. 空 can mean “Empty”, “Void”, “Sky”, or “Space”. 門 can also mean “gate” or “door”, but in this case refers to a sect. Given the sect’s specialty, I chose the name “Spaceless Sect”. Possibly interesting tidbit: the “space door” that Thieving Heaven was looking for in Reverend Insanity is 空門, so you could (in a different context) translate 不空門 as “not space door”.

[^8]: *Ning Xiaoren* – 宁晓仁 – Xiaoren can possibly mean something like “knowing compassion”. But it also sounds like 小人, which means “small-minded person” or “villain”.

[^9]: *Ning Ze* – 宁责 – Ze means something like “blame” or “reproach”.

[^10]: *Up-Down As-You-Wish Cable* – 上下如意索 – 上下 are “Up and Down”. 如意 you may have seen pinyinized as “Ruyi” - it literally means “according to your thoughts”. Sun Wukong’s staff, which changes size as he wishes, is called the “Ruyi Jingu Bang” – As-You-Wish Gold-Banded Cudgel.

[^11]: *jin* – 斤 – An ancient Chinese unit of measurement equivalent to half a kilogram, or just over one pound.

[^12]: *Iron Will Gray Armor* – 苍铁汉甲 – 铁汉 literally means “man of iron” but refers to strong will or determination. 苍 refers to a number of colors (blue, green, gray), but the narrative describes its color as silvery so gray is correct. It also may connote decrepitude or decay. In proper order it’s “Gray Iron Will Armor”, but that sounds a bit off so I changed it to “Iron Will Gray Armor”.

[^13]: *Ning Zhuo* – 宁拙 – Zhuo means “simple” or “unsophisticated”, to put it nicely; there is a saying 勤能补拙 (qin neng bu zhuo) which means “diligence can make up for one’s dullness”.

Chapter 2: Ning Zhuo

Today was a big day for the Ning Clan. The results of the clan examination were being announced.

Ning Ze and his wife Wang Lan^[^1] sat in the hall early in the morning, waiting to hear the results of their family's two juniors.

After birth, the children of the Ning Clan had their constitutions tested annually until they were twelve or thirteen years old. Those with the qualifications to cultivate were sent to the clan's private academy and had their studies subsidized until they were sixteen or seventeen years old, at which point they would take the graduation examination.

For these young cultivators, this examination determined their fates. Those who ranked in the top thirty would be allowed to join the Ning Clan's family industry, granting them bright futures.

Wang Lan seemed to be calmly drinking tea, but her eyes darted to the door from time to time, unable to hide her anxiety and anticipation.

Meanwhile, Ning Ze's eyes were dim and his mood was gloomy.

He had waited until dawn, but the Huang Family Ghost Trio never contacted him.

"They failed!

"I didn't expect Hanging-Hair Traveler to be so fierce!

"But it's still okay.

"When I contacted the Huang Family Ghost Trio, I didn't reveal my true self. Hanging-Hair Traveler won't be able to find me.

"Hmph, the Huang Family Ghost Trio were all talk! With a Soul-Suppressing Talisman, a Verdant Blade Mantis, and fighting three against one, they still lost! I really misjudged them.

"Sigh, that Hanging-Hair Traveler... What should I do now?"

Ning Ze had been forced to take a risk, but his plan failed miserably. Now, he was agonizing over how to explain things to the junior patriarch.

"Dad, Mom, I passed the exam, I'm in the top 30!" At this moment, a young man rushed into the room and shouted excitedly.

"Really? Ji'er, you really passed?!" Wang Lan immediately stood up with a face full of surprise.

The young cultivator, Ning Ji[^2], said loudly, "Of course! Mom, you don't even believe your own son?"

"Oh?" Ning Ze looked up and saw his son's proud and unrestrained smile.

Normally, Ning Ji's grades hovered around 40th place. Ning Ze didn't expect that his son would suddenly perform so well this time.

This bit of good news slightly raised his spirits.

Ning Ji continued speaking in a loud voice. "Dad, Mom, I've made you proud this time. Don't I always say that I know what I'm doing? My grades aren't all that great usually, but that's just because I'm not giving it my all.

"Unlike a certain someone!

"There's someone here who's usually always in the top 30. But this time, he messed up and finished in 31st place. That's right, he failed!"

As Ning Ji said this, he turned around with a sarcastic expression and looked at a young man in white who followed him into the house.

This white-robed young man was dressed simply and had clear eyes. His face was full of guilt and deep disappointment.

"Uncle, aunt." The young man in white, Ning Zhuo, greeted the couple.

Wang Lan looked at him and shouted, "What? Little Zhuo, you failed?!"

Ning Ze's expression darkened, and he immediately stretched out his hand. "Show me your report card."

Ning Zhuo took out his report card and handed it to his uncle. Looking down at the report card, Ning Ze's expression became even gloomier.

Shaking the paper in his hand, he said angrily, "Little Zhuo, how could you have made such a mistake?"

"I recall that your mechanical arts skills are pretty good. Back then, that mechanical parrot you created even won praise from the elders.

"Mechanical arts is obviously your specialty, so why was your score so low this time?"

"Sigh, if it wasn't for this low score, you would definitely have ranked in the top 30!"

Wang Lan's gaze grew sharp. "Little Zhuo, tell me honestly. Have you been taking on private commissions from a mechanical workshop again?"

Before Ning Zhuo could answer, his aunt sighed, "How many times have I told you to stop thinking about money all the time? Youngsters like you should focus on their studies.

“Alas, you invested all your effort into making money. This is like throwing away watermelons to pick up sesame seeds.

“Now look! Outside the top 30! Locked out of the family industry!!”

Hearing this, Ning Zhuo finally plucked up his courage and said, “Aunt, I heard from my classmates that we can use connections...”

Before he could finish speaking, Wang Lan interrupted him: “Use connections? Do you know how many spirit stones it takes to use connections? Do you know how many people we’ll need to bribe to get you in through a backdoor?”

“You didn’t do well in the exam, so now you want me and your uncle to go running around and find you some connections?”

“How dare you!”

“If you knew this would happen, why didn’t you listen to me in the first place?”

“I told you so many times to focus on your studies and ignore the sparse spirit stones you could get from those private commissions.

“Did they do you any good?”

“If you had ranked among the top 30 and joined the family industry, you would be able to earn so much more. You would have fewer things to do and more time to cultivate.”

Ning Zhuo suddenly raised his head, his face flush with indignation. Gritting his teeth, he said, “Uncle, aunt – I, Ning Zhuo, will take responsibility for my own actions!”

“Since I’m 31st, that’s that.

“You’ve taken good care of me over the years, and I am extremely grateful. This exam’s results are because of my own actions. I won’t deny it!

“I’ll take responsibility!

“I’m sure that I’ll be able to find a way to support myself outside.”

Having said this, Ning Zhuo bowed and continued, “Uncle, aunt, my classmates are waiting for me to join them for a celebratory meal. If there’s nothing else, I’ll be going now.”

Ning Ze stared at Ning Zhuo in silence.

As for Wang Lan, she waved her hand in disgust. “Go on, then, go! You sure are carefree, still in the mood to celebrate with your classmates even after doing so poorly in the exam!”

Ning Zhuo didn’t stay any longer, turning and leaving in indignation.

His cousin, Ning Ji, sat down comfortably in a chair.

As Wang Lan turned to look at Ning Ji, her expression changed from anger to elation. “It’s still my son who’s the best!”

She pushed the snacks on the table toward him, saying, “Hurry and eat. These are Golden Flake Jade Dew Cakes from Golden Restaurant. Eating these will strengthen your sea of consciousness and bolster your divine intent. This will be of great help for your cultivation and even your future Foundation Establishment!”

Ning Ji’s eyes lit up, and he immediately picked up a cake and put it in his mouth.

The Golden Flake Jade Dew Cake had a unique texture; the cake portion was soft and chewy, while the golden flakes were crispy. Deep inside,

there was a delicious liquid filling.

Ning Ji swallowed the first cake in three bites, feeling a refreshing breath of cool energy rise from his stomach and rush straight to his head. He immediately exclaimed, “Delicious!”

“Then eat more. Eat all of them.” His mother smiled.

After eating the remaining three cakes, Ning Ji licked his lips, seemingly still unsatisfied. “As expected of Golden Restaurant, so delicious! How come there are only four? Is that all?”

His father snorted coldly and said, “Each of these cakes is worth 20 spirit stones. You just swallowed almost a hundred spirit stones, and you still want more?”

“If you want more, then work harder! Don’t slack off! You should do your best for the clan and earn enough money to buy yourself spirit food with your own two hands.”

Ning Ji shouted, “Dad, haven’t I made you proud this time? Just think, if my grades were like they were before, you would have to run around bribing people to get me into the family business. Since I did so well in the clan examination and saved you hundreds of spirit stones, what’s wrong with me eating some pastries from Golden Restaurant?”

“Besides, eating these will strengthen my spirit and improve my cultivation. If I’d had these sorts of resources before, my grades would have been even better.”

Seeing his son talking back, Ning Ze glared and was about to scold him.

Wang Lan quickly said, “Okay, okay, let’s stop here.”

Then she shot a glare at her husband. "My son did well in the exam, so we should be praising him! But after only a few words, you're ready to scold him again.

"Don't just look at how playful he is normally; he's reliable when it counts. Nothing like that Ning Zhuo! That brat's grades are usually good, so I let my guard down. But in the end, he's the one who causes us the most worry!

"Hmph, he turned around and left after I just criticized him a little. How hot-headed! He even ran out for a celebratory meal. Does he have no shame?"

Ning Ji sneered. "Ning Zhuo is too arrogant, unwilling to listen to Mom and Dad's advice. By the way, our family isn't actually going to waste money and help him get in through the backdoor, right?"

Ning Ze snorted coldly. "That's not something you need to worry about."

Seeing his father growing angry again, Ning Ji subconsciously shrank back. But then, remembering his score in this exam, he loudly said, "Mom, Ning Zhuo went out to eat, so I want to go too! Give me some money. You don't know just how hard I worked for this exam!"

"Alright, alright." Wang Lan smiled and handed Ning Ji a bag of spirit stones. After grabbing the bag, Ning Ji stood up and left.

He walked out of the Ning Clan's territory and onto the street, but didn't rush to his favorite restaurant. Instead, he wandered around.

He was looking for Ning Zhuo.

Normally, there would never be a chance for Ning Ji to make fun of Ning Zhuo. Now that he had this opportunity, he obviously had to make

the best of it.

Thus, he looked around everywhere but couldn't find his cousin.

After asking several waiters, he learned that Ning Zhuo had never been to these restaurants, or even been seen nearby.

Ning Ji slapped his forehead in sudden comprehension. "That kid was just pretending. How could he have gone for a celebratory meal? Right now, he's probably crying his eyes out in that crappy house where his mother died!

"Alright then, I won't worry about him. Time to eat."

Spirit food wasn't just delicious; it also had wondrous benefits for a person's cultivation, making Ning Ji salivate just thinking about it.

Ning Ji's guess was partially correct; Ning Zhuo had indeed returned to his own home.

Compared to the place where his aunt and uncle lived, Ning Zhuo's house was much more humble.

Gently closing the gate, Ning Zhuo walked through the small courtyard and entered the inner room. This place was his bedroom, as well as his study.

Although the furniture here was rather shabby, everything was neat and organized. Ning Zhuo touched the stone lion on the desk, and a faint light flickered across it.

This indicated that no one had been here while he was away.

Turning around, Ning Zhuo walked over to his bed and twisted the railing. Suddenly, a mechanical creaking sound echoed out.

The bed immediately moved to the side, revealing a passage leading underground. Ning Zhuo stepped onto the wooden ladder and lowered himself down into the underground room step by step.

Once his feet were planted firmly on the ground, he touched a switch on the wall and the bed above him returned to its original position.

Although the light from above had disappeared, the small underground room was illuminated by bright runes lining the walls.

At this moment, the loss and disappointment on Ning Zhuo's face melted away, replaced by a serene expression. He sat down at his workbench, which was littered with various mechanical parts.

Ning Zhuo then pulled open a drawer on the right to reveal numerous pastries. Each pastry was wrapped in paper that displayed the logo of Golden Restaurant.

After reaching in and grabbing five pastries at random, Ning Zhuo activated his magical power and burned the paper wrappers. However, the Golden Flake Jade Dew Cakes inside were left completely unharmed.

Obviously, he had repeated this action many times already, to the point of absolute perfection.

Ning Zhuo's gaze grew distant as he chewed the cakes thoroughly. In his mind, he was reviewing today's performance. This was a habit he had maintained for over ten years.

"There should be no problems. I just didn't expect the others to perform so poorly in this exam.

"When I was looking at the ranking, I almost thought that I messed up and entered the top 30 by accident."

Notes:

[^1]: *Wang Lan* – 王蘭 – *Wang* is a common surname meaning “king”, and *Lan* means “orchid” or “graceful”.

[^2]: *Ning Ji* – 寧忌 – *Ji* means “jealous” or “envious”

Chapter 3: Will

Gentle spiritual light filled the underground workshop.

Sitting at the workbench, Ning Zhuo checked the storage bags in his hand again. These bag were his loot from the black market battle with the Huang Family Ghost Trio.

After making sure that it was safe, Ning Zhuo began cracking the micro-formation on the first storage bag. By imitating the original owner's aura and divine sense, he could fool the storage bags into opening.

The first bag contained a small sum of spirit stones, a Verdant Blade Mantis spirit pet, and some materials used for ghost cultivation, including darkness essence, soul extract, and netherworld flowers.

The second bag contained several hundreds of spirit stones, some more ghost cultivation materials, a ball of yin wind, and a jade slip for a ghost cultivation method called the "Yin Bone Art", which allowed a person to modify their bone structure.

The third bag belonged to the leader of the Huang Family Ghost Trio. This storage bag had two layers of protective formations, vastly increasing the time and effort required to crack it.

"Interesting." Ning Zhuo's eyes sparkled.

The harder and more difficult it was, the hotter his fighting spirit burned. He devoted himself to the task, enjoying the process of solving the formations. After nearly half an hour, he finally cracked the seal on the storage bag.

As soon as he opened it, the head of a little ghost pounced toward Ning Zhuo's face. Ning Zhuo snorted, having secretly made preparations already. At the critical moment, the Buddha Heart Demon Seal in his sea of consciousness flickered and sealed the little ghost's movement. Then, the defensive formation on the workbench activated, and the little ghost was instantly blasted to nothingness.

This little ghost seemed to be the trio leader's final act of defiance. With its defeat, the storage bag was laid completely bare to Ning Zhuo.

There were more than a thousand spirit stones in the storage bag, as well as two ghost cultivation jade slips. One of the jade slips described a cultivation technique called the "Netherworld Heart Sutra", and the other was a spell jade slip entitled "Detailed Explanation of the Soul Guiding Art". There were also many cultivation materials, and they weren't just limited to things used for ghost cultivation.

"Fire essence?!" Ning Zhuo's pupils contracted slightly as he noticed ten jin of fire essence. A joyful expression suddenly appeared on his face.

Holding back his excitement, Ning Zhuo made another grab at the drawer full of Golden Flake Jade Dew Cakes. Circulating his magical power, he burned away the wrappers on the cakes. The ashes that flew out seemed to call to mind the ashes of a corpse incinerated in a furnace. Ning Zhuo stuffed all the cakes in his hand into his mouth, chewing loudly.

Illuminated by the spiritual light, his rosy lips moved up and down, occasionally exposing his bright white teeth. The Golden Flake Jade Dew Cakes were crushed between his teeth, their liquid filling spilled out and mixed together in his mouth. They were like the many

cultivators who had fallen in his hands, wailing in despair as their flesh and blood were ground up to fuel Ning Zhuo's growth.

The world of cultivation was cruel. Without his black market business selling As-You-Wish Cables and the contributions of these demonic cultivators, how could Ning Zhuo afford to eat so many Golden Flake Jade Dew Cakes?

Still munching on the cakes, Ning Zhuo happily tallied up the proceeds from yesterday's black market visit.

Selling Up-Down As-You-Wish Cables had netted him 24,000 spirit stones, the bulk of which were contributed by his uncle Ning Ze purchasing 80 cables on behalf of the Ning Clan.

Compared to this, the spirit stones from the Huang Family Ghost Trio were but a pittance.

"My Up-Down As-You-Wish Cables are the best ropes on the market when it comes to exploring caves and other rough terrain. That's why they've always been a steady source of business.

"They bought so many. It seems like the Ning Clan is getting ready to do something big?

"Sigh, this world of cultivation is really ruthless! There are always people out there with evil intentions who are ready to bully ordinary kids like me.

"Since those three ghost cultivators have to resort to robbing people, it's only to be expected that they're so poor. But this ten jin of fire essence is really an unexpected surprise.

"Now I've accumulated a total of one thousand jin of fire essence. It's enough!"

Ning Zhuo had been secretly accumulating fire essence for several years. For safety's sake, he would only purchase a small amount from the market every time, building up his reserves little by little. Going by his previous speed, this last ten jin of fire essence would take more than a month.

But now, this sudden windfall of fire essence directly filled his final deficit.

After tallying up his profits, Ning Zhuo also calculated his losses from the previous night's battle.

He took out a silver-gray token from his arms. The front of the token read "Iron" and the back read "Gray".

Ning Zhuo tossed it lightly, and the token stretched and expanded, emitting dazzling light all the while. When the light faded, the mechanical armor called the Iron Will Gray Armor was floating quietly in the air.

Ning Zhuo opened a compartment in the spine of the mechanical armor, revealing an embedded Foundation Establishment Pill.

"There's only 30% of the Foundation Establishment Pill left."

This pill was extremely important. It was because of this pill that the Iron Will Gray Armor could display the battle prowess of Foundation Establishment despite Ning Zhuo's own cultivation in the Qi Refining stage.

"Once the Foundation Establishment Pill is fully used up, the Iron Will Gray Armor will become unusable.

"Sigh, finding Foundation Establishment Pills is too difficult." A slight frown appeared on Ning Zhuo's face.

This was his biggest loss during the battle yesterday.

The armor also had a new scar; the puncture mark left by the trio leader's final blow. There was nothing Ning Zhuo could do about this.

Looking closely, it was possible to see that the surface of this mechanical armor was actually scarred all over.

Some were very old, while others had been added during battles when Ning Zhuo donned the armor to fight.

"Mom..." Touching the old scars, Ning Zhuo's eyes grew melancholy.

Fourteen years ago, when he was only two years old, his mother had given him many instructions before dying.

He learned that inside Fire Persimmon Mountain, there was a mechanical immortal city called the Lava Immortal Palace. The palace spirit had secretly selected some cultivators to inherit the immortal city, and Ning Zhuo's mother, in the Foundation Establishment stage, was one of them.

The immortal city was full of extremely difficult tests. Because of her outstanding strength, Ning Zhuo's mother was jointly targeted by the other inheritors and eventually suffered an irreversible injury.

Scenes of that day fourteen years ago floated into Ning Zhuo's mind...

"The immortal city is continuously weakening, and the selection standard is being lowered in turn. Zhuo'er, by the time you turn fourteen years old, the selection standard of the mechanical immortal city will have dropped to the Qi Refining stage. This will be your great opportunity!"

“Zhuo’er, you must study mechanical arts well and avoid letting others know your skills. You must design your mechanical constructs on your own, assemble them on your own, and operate them on your own. These are the contents of the tests in the mechanical immortal city.

“If you are among the top few candidates, you will be recognized as a mechanical arts talent and cultivated by the mechanical city. This is especially important for you; without a strong background, the cultivation resources of the mechanical immortal city will become even more essential.

“Absolutely do not use the Ning Clan’s cultivation techniques to reach the Foundation Establishment stage! I was a mechanical arts talent as well, but as a Foundation Establishment cultivator, my dantian is already fixed, making it impossible to change my cultivation technique. Many tests in the Lava Immortal Palace were twice as difficult because I didn’t practice the cultivation technique left by Three Schools Supreme Sage, and I was eventually unable to keep going.”

At this point, Ning Zhuo’s mother broke out into a coughing fit, and the two-year-old Ning Zhuo cried out in panic: “Mom, stop talking! You’re coughing up blood!”

Ning Zhuo’s mother reached out and stroked the little Ning Zhuo’s head, her eyes full of reluctance and worry: “Zhuo’er, I’m sorry that I can’t protect you. You’ve lost both your father and mother... In the future, you will be all alone and can only rely on yourself.

“Don’t be too loyal to the clan. This was your father’s mistake!

“Before your father died, he asked the junior patriarch Ning Xiaoren to take care of you. But that person is two-faced and can’t be relied on.

“As for your uncle and aunt, one is too proud while the other is too stingy. Neither are good people. Remember to be wary of them.

“Sometimes, the family and friends around you can be more dangerous than your enemies!

“Don’t act too smart. With me and your father gone, you won’t have any real backing. You have to conceal yourself well. Don’t act too dumb, either; stay mediocre. Make sure to grow up normally, silently accumulating your strength without drawing any attention to your self.

“I’ve seen too many geniuses die young...

“I will leave my Iron Will Gray Armor for you to protect yourself. It has the power of the Foundation Establishment stage.

“And this magical treasure – the Buddha Heart Demon Seal! This is what I obtained by chance from the Lava Immortal Palace. You must not expose it.”

When Ning Zhuo’s mother spoke to this point, her voice was already at its limit.

Tears flowed ceaselessly down her face as she stared at the two-year-old Ning Zhuo. She wanted to look at him and never stop, but her sight gradually grew dim.

As her life neared its end, she said hesitantly: “I don’t know if it’s right to tell you all this.

“Zhuo’er, take good care of yourself. If it really can’t be done, just give up on the Lava Immortal Palace.

“Living is the most important. I hope that you live, and live well!

“I will be happy as long as you’re alive.”

The two-year-old Ning Zhuo tightly grasped his mother's bloodied clothes: "Mom, mom, don't keep talking. I don't want you to die, you can't die, waah..."

Taking her final breath, Ning Zhuo's mother said: "Zhuo'er, don't be afraid... Mother is here, I will watch over you from the netherworld..."

The next moment, her heart stopped beating, and her hand slowly slid down from Ning Zhuo's head.

The two-year-old Ning Zhuo's body trembled as if he had been electrocuted. He suddenly raised his head... back in the present, as a sixteen-year-old.

The tears on his formerly childish face were now replaced by the resolute expression of a mature teenager.

Shouldering the will and expectations of his mother before her death, he had grown up.

"Mom, the situation has changed!

"The city lord, the Zhou Clan^[^1], and the Zheng Clan^[^2] have joined forces. They're putting more effort into cleaning up the Scarlet Flame Monster^[^3] Volcanic Cavern, which has greatly reduced the damage to the Lava Immortal Palace. Since the immortal palace's situation is still fine, the palace spirit has yet to lower the selection standard.

"The Ning Clan also discovered the Lava Immortal Palace this year. If I wait for them to join in the defense as well, then just how long will I have to wait for the standards to be lowered?

"It might not happen in my entire life!

“The few major forces of Fire Persimmon Immortal City are doing everything they can to cover up the Lava Immortal Palace and swallow this opportunity by themselves. How could they allow me to get a slice of the pie?

“That’s why I have to take matters into my own hands!

“Now, I’ve finally accumulated enough fire essence to bomb the immortal palace, damaging it to the point that it will lower its selection standard.

“The only thing left is the explosive fire monkey!”

Notes:

[^1] Zhou Clan – 周家 – Zhou is a surname that can mean “circle”. It’s also the name of several historical dynasties.

[^2] Zheng Clan – 鄭家 – Zheng is a surname that originates from a state in the Zhou Dynasty (same Zhou as the above).

[^3] Scarlet Flame Monster – 赤焰妖 – You may have seen this translated as “Scarlet Flame Demon” or something similar. In xianxia, there are both 妖 (yao) and 魔 (mo) which are often translated as “demon”, but they’re different things. It seems like in this novel, 魔 is more of a way of life (i.e. demonic path, Demon Venerable) while 妖 are like upgraded versions of beasts.

Chapter 4: Deep Knowledge^[^1]

Ning Zhuo walked over to the furnace in the corner. A raging flame blazed inside the furnace, constantly licking at a mechanical monkey that stood half a human high.

This mechanical monkey was standing straight, its bright red fur extremely lifelike. However, its muscles were slowly melting from the heat and flowed out from every crack in the frame.

The Lava Immortal Palace was hidden inside a volcano. Ning Zhuo needed to have this explosive fire monkey carry a thousand jin of fire essence, swim through the lava, and self-destruct once it reached the surface of the immortal palace.

But with its current structure, its muscles would melt before it got there.

“Cloud-patterned soft silver doesn’t work. Let’s try the next one.”

Ning Zhuo sat back down at the workbench. According to his plan, the next material to test was petroleum mud.

The reddish-brown petroleum mud exuded a pungent smell.

Ning Zhuo took out a small wooden hammer and began striking the petroleum mud. Every time the hammer struck, a dull thud rang out, and clods of dirt fell out of the mud. Whenever a spark appeared on the reddish-brown petroleum mud, a burst of cold air would emerge from the wooden hammer and extinguish it.

This small wooden hammer was something Ning Zhuo had designed especially to deal with petroleum mud.

If an examiner from the clan examination saw this scene, they would immediately give Ning Zhuo an “exceptional” for his talisman score.

The three most common scores were “inferior”, “average”, and “superior”.

As for “exceptional”, it was extremely rare, and in any given exam it was likely that not even one would appear. It was a score given only when the normal standards were no longer enough to describe a student’s excellence!

After all the dirt was cleaned out, what remained was a chunk of reddish mud covered in a layer of oil.

Ning Zhuo took out a cotton handkerchief and used it to cover the petroleum mud. As he input magical power, the formation on the handkerchief quickly absorbed the layer of oil.

This handkerchief was also designed by Ning Zhuo. Unlike the hammer, however, it didn’t use the power of talismans, instead having a micro-formation arranged on it.

This micro-formation was also at the level of “exceptional”.

After carefully making sure that the petroleum mud was properly processed, he began to knead it.

The processed petroleum mud was sticky and pliable, and as Ning Zhuo kneaded it into a soft and delicate state, any remaining impurities in the mud were flushed out by the infusion of magical power.

Ning Zhuo then took apart one of the mechanical monkey’s arms and attached the processed petroleum mud to the bones. Under the illumination of spirit light, his ten fair fingers moved swiftly and delicately without regard for the passage of time. At this moment, he

exuded a diligent sort of charm.

As he molded the petroleum mud, blood-red muscles gradually covered the mechanical monkey's arm bones. Of course, Ning Zhuo didn't just shape the exterior with his hands. His magical power coursed through the petroleum mud, shaping it from the inside as well.

If you took out a knife and gently sliced the mud open, you would find that the insides of the red mud had already taken the shape of entwining muscle fibers.

This incredible proficiency in shaping material would be enough to make the academy elder cry out in shock. If Ning Zhuo revealed this skill, the academy elder would definitely give him attention and promote him heavily. After all, the appearance of such a genius would of course be due to the academy elder's own talent and hard work.

After the molding was complete, Ning Zhuo put the arm through a variety of tests.

"No good. The petroleum mud's heat resistance is excellent, but its compatibility with magical power is rather poor. I'll have to improve it."

Ning Zhuo began to think.

"Petroleum mud mixed with thunder sand will turn into an explosive. It's often used to blast open mountains or fend off monsters.

"Petroleum mud mixed with different poisons can be refined into poison pills. When crushed, these pills will release poisonous smoke that can block enemies.

"Petroleum mud can also be mixed with coal stone. If you then place it into a furnace, it will burn stably at a high temperature for a long time."

. . .

Over the years, Ning Zhuo had tried to learn everything he could. During his free days, he would often stay in the clan library from dawn to dusk, forgetting to even eat or sleep.

No one knew that Ning Zhuo, who looked ordinary, could actually be considered a human-shaped library!

Ning Zhuo recalled everything he knew about petroleum mud, but didn't find any methods of improving it.

"It doesn't matter. I'll devise a formula myself!"

The ambitious young man's eyes shone with confidence.

"Petroleum mud is warm in nature, related to the blood vessels of the heart and liver. Its heat can expel moisture and chilliness from the bones. Taking a small amount can treat abdominal pain caused by the cold.

"If mixed with moonlit well water, the harmonization of fire and water can possibly reduce the overall weight.

"If the tail feathers of the firstflight bird are used as a catalyst... maybe the addition of dynamic wind will improve the petroleum mud's performance.

"The catkins of a spirit concealment willow might also work. If I put them together and take reference from the formulae of the Soft Spirit Pill and Clear Dust Powder for the ratio, it should greatly reduce the weight of the final product."

.....

Ning Zhuo was quick-witted and had a deep understanding of alchemical principles. Thus, he was able to use his logic to quickly think of multiple plausible formulas.

With this degree of proficiency, an “exceptional” score in alchemy was nothing. The Ning Clan would definitely lock him up and keep him close.

Ning Zhuo began trying to refine the new mixture. Looking through his stock of ingredients, he found at least seven options to experiment with.

Moonlit well water?

Failure.

The finished mud was slightly less viscous, slightly lighter, and its fire resistance was much weaker than before.

Firstflight bird’s tail feathers?

Major failure.

What came out wasn’t mud, but a pile of dust.

Ning Zhuo happily thought: “The wind element in the firstflight bird’s feathers is too strong. I’ve gained a deeper understanding of this material.”

The third attempt was with the catkins of the spirit concealment willow.

After the catkin patterns finished sinking into the petroleum mud, its viscosity remained unchanged, its fire resistance weakened very slightly, and its weight decreased sharply. This new mixture passed the rest of Ning Zhuo’s tests one by one.

“Lucky! I didn’t expect to succeed on the third try... huh?”

Ning Zhuo hadn't been happy for long when he saw the catkin patterns in the mud float back up by themselves. This change caused the quality of the mud to immediately deteriorate.

The new mud mixture wasn't stable!

Ning Zhuo moved on to the fourth experiment. It failed.

After thinking about it, he didn't continue experimenting, but focused his attention on the formula involving the spirit concealment willow.

"This formula is almost perfect, and the issue magical power compatibility is completely solved. All I need is to make sure it's stable. What should I do?"

After solving one problem, another popped up.

Ning Zhuo wasn't discouraged at all. In fact, he eagerly immersed himself in thinking of a solution. He wasn't bored or frustrated in the slightest; there was only joy welling up from the bottom of his heart.

As his thoughts turned rapidly, he felt the value of his existence. He knew that he was creating something that didn't exist in nature!

Nothing else could match this anticipation and sense of accomplishment.

Others might feel tortured, but for Ning Zhuo, thinking so hard only made him feel bliss.

Ning Zhuo had no concept of time passing as he continued immersing himself in deep thought. Suddenly, his eyes lit up.

"To solve this problem, I'll need to use dynamic formations."

However, this kind of knowledge was far beyond the scope of what could be found in the Ning Clan's academy.

Ning Zhuo stood up and paced back and forth in the underground workshop.

After thinking for a moment, he stopped and slightly raised his head, having made up his mind: “Chen Cha^[^2]... is a well-known formation master who is skilled in dynamic formations. More importantly, he’s also a mechanical art master.

“It’s time for me to contact him.”

Notes:

[^1]: The title of this chapter is 开物, which is an idiom referring to knowledge of the truth of all things. It’s also part of this novel’s real title, 仙工开物, which is a play on the real-life 天工开物, which is a kind of encyclopedia of science and technology. If you were to translate the title more literally, it might be something like “Knowledge of the Works of Immortals”, or “Knowledge of Immortal Craftsmanship”. 开 and 物 separately have even more definitions, so it might also be “Operating the Works of Immortals” or something like that. This is all really just gleaned from wiktionary + google translated baidu though, so take it with a grain of salt.

[^2] Chen Cha – 陳茶 – Chen is a surname, and Cha means tea.

Chapter 5: An Outstanding Mechanical Construct

The Flying Disk Workshop was a small and inconspicuous little workshop.

Inside this simple workshop, Chen Cha frowned as he looked at a semi-finished mechanical construct on the table.

Chen Cha was a black-robed old man with a gray beard and sunken eyes. Currently, he was sitting on a mechanical chair that floated several chi^[1] off the ground. His thoughts turned rapidly, but he couldn't come up with a solution.

His blueprint had encountered another wall.

"Just how long will this one take to solve?" Chen Cha sighed.

There was no certainty when it came to designing mechanical blueprints. Sometimes, a problem could be figured out after one or two days, while other times, it might take weeks or months. In fact, the last time Chen Cha ran into a problem like this, it took a whole year to overcome it.

Chen Cha looked at the account book on his desk, and his expression darkened.

Designing an outstanding mechanical construct always required inspiration to come up with creative ideas. Chen Cha had a solid foundation and was particularly skilled in formations, but his creativity was lacking and flashes of insight were rare.

Back then, he didn't think that this would be the case, so he had borrowed money to open this mechanical workshop. Unfortunately, reality gave him a hard slap in the face.

Not only had he used up his family's assets, he was even burdened with external debt. When riding a tiger, it's hard to get off; by now, even if he sold the whole workshop, it wouldn't be enough.

It was too late for regrets. Chen Cha knew that his only way out was to design a breakout mechanical construct. Only something that would sell for tons of money in the market could save him.

Knock, knock, knock.

There was a knock on the door.

Chen Cha frowned slightly: "What is it?"

A voice came from beyond the door: "Master, a visitor has come and wants to ask you for advice."

Chen Cha nodded: "Bring him to me."

He was currently short of money and desperately needed to pay off his debts. Under normal circumstances, he wouldn't take on any consultation requests, but he had no choice now but to make money wherever he could.

A while later, Ning Zhuo slowly walked into the workshop: "This junior is called Ning Zhuo. I'm here to meet Master Chen Cha."

The old man grunted, appearing dignified but secretly looking Ning Zhuo up and down.

Ning Zhuo was wearing a clean white robe. His eyes were calm and clear, and his face was tender with youth.

Chen Cha's gaze lingered on the jade pendant at Ning Zhuo's waist.

That jade pendant was engraved with a single word – "Ning".

"The Ning Clan?" Chen Cha's eyes flickered.

Fire Persimmon Immortal City had four major forces. The first was the City Lord Mansion; the current city lord was a cultivator in the Nascent Soul stage. The other three were “Formations” Zhou Clan, “Artifacts” Zheng Clan, and “Talismans” Ning Clan.

Chen Cha felt slightly happy as he thought: “Since he’s from a big clan, this young man could be quite rich. I might be able to make a lot. I’ll point out some of his shortcomings later so he keeps asking questions.”

After signing a business contract, Chen Cha invited Ning Zhuo to take a seat. This contract bound both parties and ensured that they would keep the conversation strictly confidential.

Chen Cha took a sip of bitter tea, then asked Ning Zhuo for details with a calm expression.

Ning Zhuo explained that he was designing a blueprint for a mechanical construct and had run into a problem.

Chen Cha immediately smiled internally and thought to himself: “You too?”

However, he didn’t take it seriously.

As a mechanical arts cultivator, workshop owner, and purveyor of knowledge, he had encountered many people like this Ning Zhuo.

“Youngsters always think that they’re special.

“But the mechanical constructs they design are unbearably bad! Some even have contradictory structures, causing them to immediately collapse the moment magical power enters them.”

Of course, these were just Chen Cha’s private thoughts. On the surface, he nodded slightly and indicated for Ning Zhuo to continue.

Ning Zhuo said, “There are always casualties during the annual Fire Persimmon Festival, so I designed a mechanical construct that can pick fire persimmons.

“I named it the explosive fire monkey, and the blueprint is almost complete, except for one last thing...”

Chen Cha grew impatient and waved his hand. “Okay, okay. Let me take a look.”

Ning Zhuo took the mechanical monkey out from his storage bag.

Chen Cha was slightly stunned and couldn’t help but exclaim internally.

The explosive fire monkey’s smooth fur was a gorgeous red, drawing Chen Cha’s attention the moment it appeared.

As a cultivator in the Foundation Establishment stage, Chen Cha naturally had divine sense. He immediately unleashed his divine sense to investigate.

A moment later, his eyebrows were about to rise high, but he barely managed to suppress it in time.

“This mechanical monkey isn’t simple!” Although Chen Cha’s design skills weren’t very good, there were no problems with his vision. He immediately noticed that this explosive fire monkey had many special features.

Chen Cha reached out and touched the explosive fire monkey’s smooth and sleek fur, admiring internally: “It’s sewn together so tightly, like one cohesive whole. The fur is lined with talisman runes, making it extraordinarily tough. The craftsmanship is exquisite and meticulous, comparable to an old tailor with many years of experience.”

He wanted to point out some flaws, but couldn't.

All he could do was lightly say: "This basic fur stitching isn't bad."

Ning Zhuo nodded in agreement and said: "Mm, I did it according to the traditional spiritual embroidery method, using the pelts of some fire velvet rats. Since the rat pelts were too small, I could only use threads to sew many of them together. Unfortunately, this means that the heat resistance along the seams is much weaker."

"Oh, this is your work?" Chen Cha raised his eyes and looked at Ning Zhuo in surprise.

Design skill didn't equate to crafting skill.

Ning Zhuo was this young, but already so skilled?

"Perhaps this is his specialty," Chen Cha thought to himself as he continued scanning with his divine sense.

He looked at the mechanical monkey's skeleton and thought: "Is this sky gold? Sky gold is light, durable, and has certain spatial qualities. Since it's being used for the skeleton, is it meant to store things?"

He continued looking. Noticing the formation patterns on the bones, Chen Cha thought, "Sure enough, this is a storage formation. It's arranged well, making full use of the skeleton and compressing the formation's size to the limit.

"Compressing the formation to this extent requires great skill!

"Thanks to that, this mechanical monkey can still be upgraded. The creator obviously has big future plans."

Chen Cha gave praise internally. He looked at Ning Zhuo again, then looked back at the mechanical monkey on the table.

There was nothing to criticize about its skeleton.

Chen Cha thought for a moment and said, “Choosing sky gold for the skeleton is just mindlessly following convention, nothing special. As for the minor adjustments to the formation, they’re merely building on the works of the predecessors, which doesn’t count for much.”

Chen Cha was mentally prepared for Ning Zhuo to argue back, but Ning Zhuo just nodded and said, “Actually, my first choice was the hollow snail. I planned on boiling the snail powder and mixing it with iron essence, then molding the mixture into the shape of the bones. This way, the storage capacity would be much greater than it is with sky gold. Unfortunately, hollow snails are hard to get in Fire Persimmon Immortal City.”

Chen Cha was stunned for a moment and thought, “He even knows this stuff?”

Indeed, hollow snails mixed with iron essence would be a perfect complement to the fire velvet rat pelt.

Chen Cha coughed twice, took a deep look at Ning Zhuo, and calmly said: “It’s good that you know.”

Then, he lowered his head and continued to scan with his divine sense.

Looking at the muscles of the mechanical monkey, he guessed internally: “These muscles are made of petroleum mud in order to increase the heat resistance?

“No, it’s different... This should be a new material made with petroleum mud as the base and refined through alchemical processes.

“This... is an original formula? This was actually created by the young man in front of me? What was his name again?

"Ning Zhuo?"

Chen Cha couldn't help but feel a little suspicious.

This Ning Zhuo was too young. Could his alchemy skills really be so incredible?

How difficult was it to create an alchemical formula? Even if it wasn't a true pill, being able to create a brand-new material was also incredibly rare.

Chen Cha suppressed his doubts and continued his investigation, sighing internally: "Aside from the material, the skill involved in shaping these muscles is also incredible. Just based on this, it's enough for the crafter to serve as the second hammer in an artifact workshop. For some minor magic artifacts, being the main hammer isn't impossible either."

Seeing this, Chen Cha couldn't help but feel slightly vexed.

This mechanical monkey was more or less perfect. No matter how much he wanted to point out some flaws, he couldn't even find any.

If he couldn't find any flaws, how could he expand this business deal?

Many people who came to Chen Cha for consultation ended paid many more spirit stones than they had planned. This was because Chen Cha pointed out many flaws and led them to ask more questions.

Apart from stressing over the high consultation fees, these people had no other complaints.

After all, Chen Cha's advice was indeed effective.

Chen Cha gritted his teeth and continued scanning.

He opened the monkey's hand, and his eyes immediately shone brightly.

Sighing internally, he thought: “This hand is exquisitely designed. Micro-formations are nested within each other, allowing the hand to move flexibly and perform complex finger movements.

“This combination is quite novel. The one who arranged these formations is very talented!

“Was this also done by Ning Zhuo?

“Who is he? A young genius from the Ning Clan? How come I’ve never heard of him?”

Chen Cha tried to remain calm as he scanned the mechanical monkey’s skull.

At this point, he finally couldn’t hide it anymore and revealed a hint of surprise.

The magic artifact inside the skull was actually a set of three stroll bullets!

“Stroll bullets are supposed to be offensive artifacts whose trajectory can be controlled at will. But these ones have been modified to fly around each other in the monkey’s brain, acting as receivers for divine sense. I’ve never seen, no, I’ve never even heard of something like this before!

“There are also many talisman runes engraved in the monkey’s skull to link up with them.

“How original! How creative!”

Chen Cha thought about it quickly and knew that this setup would be effective.

“Isn’t this kind of creativity and inspiration precisely what I’m lacking?”

Chen Cha felt slightly sour and couldn't help asking Ning Zhuo: "How did you come up with this idea?"

Ning Zhuo said: "I had no choice but to turn the stroll bullets into divine sense receivers. After all, this explosive fire monkey is something that needs to make me money. If I equipped each one with a formation disk, the cost would be too high. That's why I designed it this way.

"However, I've always felt that this isn't an ideal solution. There are still unknown hidden dangers and unstable factors."

Chen Cha's eyes lit up.

"Cost! Right, without a formation disk, this mechanical construct is extremely cheap to produce.

"Isn't this exactly what I'm looking for? With this thing's performance, it will definitely sell like crazy!

"Wait a minute..."

Chen Cha suddenly looked at Ning Zhuo and felt a little angry.

This mechanical construct could be considered flawless. What need was there to come ask him for advice?

What intentions did this young man have?

"Don't tell me he's doing this to mock me?"

But after the surge of anger, doubts arose in his heart.

"Such an incredible mechanical construct... was it really designed by this boy in front of me?

"If I were the one who designed something like this at that young of an age, I would have raised my head up high and proudly paraded it everywhere.

“This is an expression of his own ability. It’s not something any ordinary person can compare to!

“But this kid is a bit too humble...

“It’s almost as if he’s feeling guilty about stealing someone else’s work.”

Notes:

[^1]: *chi* – 尺 – a Chinese unit of length equal to a third of a meter, or approximately one foot.

Chapter 6: I, Ning Zhuo, am Merely Ordinary

Feeling suspicious, Chen Cha asked Ning Zhuo a few subtly chosen questions about the mechanical monkey. There were many aspects involved in these questions, and only the true creator would be able to answer them.

Naturally, Ning Zhuo didn't have any problems.

After talking for a bit, Chen Cha no longer had any doubts. All he felt was shock: "Could it be that he really did design and manufacture this mechanical monkey himself?

"Isn't he a disciple of the Ning Clan? The Ning Clan specializes in talismans. When did their mechanical arts become so good, to raise a genius like this?

"If he continues to grow, this child will certainly become a great figure in the future!"

Chen Cha looked at Ning Zhuo in a completely new light. Full of interest, he couldn't help asking a few more questions.

Ning Zhuo said, "This junior has already left the academy after this year's graduation exam. Senior, you have a keen eye; I've indeed always had a personal interest in mechanical arts. That's why I've collected many books and studied in private; it has nothing to do with the Ning Clan's academy."

Chen Cha stroked his beard and deliberately said, "Among the hundred arts of cultivation, the top four are alchemy, artifact refining, talisman

crafting, and formation arrangement. Mechanical arts ranks at the bottom of the hundred arts, a niche among niches. Why do you like this subject so much?”

Ning Zhuo’s thoughts turned, and he realized that the critical moment had arrived!

When he came to contact Chen Cha this time, bringing out the mechanical monkey was only part of his plan.

After pondering for a moment, his expression turned solemn: “This junior believes that the term ‘cultivation[¹’ refers to cultivating the truths of heaven and earth. The so-called hundred arts of cultivation, as applications of these truths, are essentially just tools.

“Alchemy is a tool, artifacts such as flying swords are also tools, and talismans and formations are tools as well.

“Using these tools makes cultivation more convenient and increases our success rate in various endeavors.

“And the pinnacle of these tools is mechanical arts!

“A new mechanical material is created through alchemical methods. The structure of a mechanical construct is informed by artifact refining methods. The formations and talismans on the mechanical construct also involve the skills of formation arrangement and talisman creation.

“An outstanding mechanical construct requires the clever combination of many arts of cultivation.”

Speaking to this point, Ning Zhuo paused: “As for why mechanical arts occupies the bottom ranking of the hundred arts and is considered a niche discipline, it’s because the criteria to learn and master it are the highest of all!

“On the one hand, crafting a mechanical construct requires you to master many arts of cultivation. Alchemy, artifact refining, talisman crafting, and formation arrangement are just the start. After mastering these, you still have to pick and choose combinations of countless materials and methods.

“On the other hand, designing a mechanical construct is even more difficult. It’s a severe test of your knowledge, talent, creativity, and insight. A good blueprint may take more than ten years to complete, and during those ten years, it’s not uncommon to be stuck on one problem for a long time.

“Only an outstanding blueprint can produce an outstanding mechanical construct.”

Listening to Ning Zhuo’s remarks, Chen Cha leaned back slightly. His eyes shone as he looked the boy in front of him up and down, and he couldn’t help but applaud: “Well said, well said!”

His attitude toward Ning Zhuo changed yet again.

From his previous appreciation and interest, he now felt a connection between fellow tradesmen!

Human relationships were curious things. Some people could live together day and night and be nothing more than familiar strangers, while others could find their thoughts resonating even when talking to each other for the first time.

As Chen Cha and Ning Zhuo got along better and better, the way they addressed each other changed very naturally. Chen Cha affectionately called Ning Zhuo “Little Zhuo”, and Ning Zhuo began calling the former “Old Chen”.

When Ning Zhuo brought up the issue he was facing, Chen Cha pondered for a moment before offering three plans.

Normally, he would only give a single plan. But with Ning Zhuo, he didn't hold anything back.

Ning Zhuo immediately brought up numerous questions after hearing these three plans. As for Chen Cha, he enthusiastically answered all of Ning Zhuo's questions without thinking about his consultation fees at all.

Ning Zhuo continued making suggestions and modifying the three plans, and Chen Cha happily immersed himself in the discussion.

As they chatted, the two quickly improved and optimized a chosen plan. In the end, they decided to add blood to the explosive fire monkey and have the blood carry a dynamic formation to stabilize the structure. At the same time, the blood could evaporate to dissipate heat, improving the monkey's heat resistance even more.

Chen Cha concluded, "Based on my many years of experience, once this explosive fire monkey hits the market, it'll be an instantaneous hit.

"Little Zhuo, how about handing this mechanical construct over to my Flying Disk Workshop?

"How many explosive fire monkeys could you produce by yourself? If you want to sell in bulk, you'll have to entrust a workshop to manufacture them for you.

"My Flying Disk Workshop has enough cultivators and materials to meet your manufacturing needs.

"Plus, I've been operating in Fire Persimmon Immortal City for decades already. I have many sales channels, and even some connections with

the City Lord Mansion.

“On the one hand, I can rely on my connections to avoid a certain level of taxes, increasing the profit.

“On the other, this will also serve as a kind of protection. Once your explosive fire monkey appears on the market, it will seriously infringe on the interests of the Monkey Head Gang.

“This gang specializes in raising spirit monkeys, and their main business is using these monkeys to pick the explosive fire persimmons.

“We need to prepare for them ahead of time.”

Ning Zhuo blinked and pretended to hesitate: "This..."

Chen Cha smiled and said sincerely: "Little Zhuo, I won't lie to you. This is also something that's very beneficial to me.

“It's been many years, but my Flying Disk Workshop still hasn't produced any famous creations. Your explosive fire monkey perfectly suits my needs.

“As long as the explosive fire monkey sells well, my Flying Disk Workshop's fame will grow, and business will be better and better.

“Thus, I will only take 30% of the profits from the sales of the explosive fire monkey. Moreover, I'll bear all the costs of production myself!”

Ning Zhuo shook his head: “Old Chen, I can feel your sincerity, but...”

Chen Cha stroked his beard: “Indeed, a big matter like this needs to be considered carefully. Little Zhuo, maybe you're thinking of asking your clan. But although the Ning Clan is a major cultivation clan, its influence in the mechanics industry isn't all that. If you rely on your clan for this matter, they might even just outsource it to a different

mechanical workshop.

“Little Zhuo, I’m telling the truth. If you’re curious, you can go ask around yourself!”

Ning Zhuo waved his hand: “Old Chen, my parents died when I was young, and from then on I lived with my aunt and uncle. Now that I’ve graduated from the academy, I’ve left their house and am living on my own.

“I can make my own decisions on these matters. Not once have I considered handing this mechanical construct over to the Ning Clan.

“It’s just... I have one small request.”

Chen Cha: “Oh? Tell me.”

Ning Zhuo: “I want to join your workshop to gain experience. I also want to ask for your advice; there are too many questions that I haven’t been able to find answers for. As for the consultation fees, you can deduct them from my share of the explosive fire monkey’s profits. How’s that?”

Chen Cha laughed: “Little Zhuo, it’s my Flying Disk Workshop’s fortune if you want to join us. Welcome!

“With your talent, you can become the deputy workshop owner right away.”

Ning Zhuo quickly shook his head: “That won’t do! I am but an inexperienced boy of the Ning Clan who still has much to learn. With my ability, how could I be the deputy workshop master?”

“Ordinary? You’re too humble!” Chen Cha shook his head and sighed. Internally, he thought that this kind of modesty must be a tradition of the

Ning Clan.

However, these were Ning Zhuo's true thoughts!

He fully agreed with Chen Cha's previous criticisms.

"The reason for Old Chen's kindness and praise must be because of the consultation and the profits from my mechanical constructs.

"I'm still a beginner when it comes to mechanical arts. The secret records that my mother left behind have many mechanisms that I still can't fully understand.

"Even for the explosive fire monkey, it took several years and many setbacks before reaching the current state. In the end, I had to come ask Old Chen for advice in order to complete it.

"I still need to learn more about mechanical arts."

Ning Zhuo didn't realize that Chen Cha's words of praise weren't exaggerated in the slightest, and instead based on years of real-life experience. His appreciation for the young man was completely genuine.

On the one hand, Ning Zhuo had been hiding himself, never communicating deeply with like-minded fellows until today. Thus, he didn't know just how extraordinary his skills were.

On the other, Ning Zhuo's mother's dying words had led him to always be cautious. In order to conceal himself better, he always maintained a humble mentality.

Even if he achieved some success, he would find ways to criticize himself and track down all sorts of shortcomings, ensuring that he would never grow arrogant and complacent.

For the past fourteen years, he continuously told himself: I am ordinary and mediocre. No matter what I've done, others could have done it too. I still need to work hard and never slack off...

Over time, these thoughts ingrained in him a deeply humble attitude and blinded him to his own excellence. From the bottom of his heart, he considered himself a mediocre person who still had much to learn.

But the explosive fire monkey was a mechanical construct that Chen Cha could only dream of inventing even after so many years!

After reaching an agreement with Ning Zhuo, Chen Cha called upon the full might of his workshop. He produced more than 20 mechanical monkeys in a single day and sent them to the market for sale.

That night, Ning Zhuo put the explosive fire monkey with the added dynamic formation into the furnace and conducted another heat test.

"It should be a success this time." Ning Zhuo was quite confident.

Then, his gaze grew thoughtful: "Chen Cha..."

Ning Zhuo had spent several years investigating Chen Cha and understood his character well.

Just as Chen Cha had a high opinion of Ning Zhuo, Ning Zhuo also had a high opinion of Chen Cha.

"If there are no problems with the explosive fire monkey, the next step is figuring out how to get into the Lava Immortal Palace."

The Lava Immortal Palace was hidden inside Fire Persimmon Mountain, covered in thick lava. Thus, the first thing Ning Zhuo needed to do was reach the interior of Fire Persimmon Mountain.

In fact, there was a clear path to doing so. First, he had to ascend Fire Persimmon Mountain, then dig down into the Scarlet Flame Monster Volcanic Cavern. After going through a maze of thousands of tunnels, he would eventually reach the location of the Lava Immortal Palace.

“But if a problem occurs in the Lava Immortal Palace right after my first expedition, it will be too conspicuous.

“Moreover, I’ve never entered the Scarlet Flame Monster Volcanic Cavern for all these years. It’s a bit abrupt to suddenly want to go.

“I need to find a cover.”

At this point, Ning Zhuo thought of his uncle, Ning Ze.

A plan started to take shape in his mind.

Notes:

[^1]: The term “cultivation” here is 修真, literally “cultivating truth”. Some other common variants are 修炼 (refining cultivation), 修仙 (cultivating immortality), or 修行 (doing cultivation)

Chapter 7: Let Ning Zhuo Come Home

The junior patriarch of the Ning Clan summoned Ning Ze once more, inquiring about the progress of his mission regarding Hanging-Hair Traveler.

Gritting his teeth, Ning Ze gave his report.

Bang!

Junior patriarch Ning Xiaoren was completely infuriated, picking up the inkstone on his desk and flinging it outward.

The inkstone struck Ning Ze's forehead, immediately drawing blood. However, Ning Ze didn't dare to wipe it away; he fell to his knees, crying and wailing: "Lord junior patriarch, it's not that I didn't try hard enough. I really did try my best, but that Hanging-Hair Traveler is too stubborn!

"My competence is lacking. This task is truly too much for me.

"Junior patriarch, you think too highly of me. You overestimate my ability. I don't have enough confidence and intelligence to complete this task."

Ning Ze didn't dare to tell anyone about the Huang Family Ghost Trio; that was something he'd done on his own.

He had wanted to get away from this task for a long time already. Now that the situation had reached this point, he finally gave up and admitted his incompetence, boldly stating that he couldn't complete the mission!

“You, you, you!!” The junior patriarch was so angry that his fingers were shaking. For a moment, he was speechless at Ning Ze’s shamelessness.

He leaned back in his chair and took several breaths to compose himself, then waved his hand: “Since you’ve failed to accomplish such a simple task, I’ll give it to someone else. Get out of here! Just looking at trash like you gives me a headache.”

Ning Ze hurriedly bid farewell, but before he could walk out the door, the junior patriarch stopped him again.

“Hold on!”

Ning Ze’s heart skipped a beat. He immediately turned around and bowed. “What is it, junior patriarch?”

The junior patriarch spoke slowly: “I saw Ning Zhuo’s name on the examination ranking list. He was in 31st place; as his uncle, don’t you have something to say?”

Ning Ze smiled bitterly: “Speaking of Little Zhuo, I too am deeply troubled. Now that he’s grown up, that child thinks he can go his own way. He argued with my wife and I after the exam results came out yesterday.

“Sigh, Little Zhuo was too young when he lost his parents, and we haven’t raised him well. That might be why he’s grown up with a stubborn temperament and reclusive personality. He’s very hardheaded and told us not to use any connections, because he thought that it would make him lose face.”

The junior patriarch fixed his eyes on Ning Ze.

“Ning Ze, you know very well that Ning Zhong^[^1] – Ning Zhuo’s father and your brother – once saved my life. I swore to him then that I would take care of Ning Zhuo and cultivate him well.

“It’s fine for a child to be stubborn. Are you also going to be stubborn?”

Ning Ze bowed and said: “Junior patriarch, I understand. I will go back and persuade Ning Zhuo to change his mind.”

“Good.” The junior patriarch waved his hand and issued an ultimatum: “If you can’t even handle this minor matter, there’s no need for you to continue being our clan’s procurement manager!”

Ning Ze felt like a heavy stone was pressing down on his heart. He returned home with a gloomy expression.

When Ning Zhuo’s aunt, Wang Lan, saw her husband, she immediately exclaimed: “Husband, how did you get hurt?!”

“How else? The junior patriarch struck me.” Ning Ze sighed.

Wang Lan said angrily, “That Ning Xiaoren sure is something! If he’s so capable, why doesn’t he go recruit Hanging-Hair Traveler himself? All he can do is order his subordinates around.”

While complaining, Wang Lan gently applied medicine to the wound on Ning Ze’s forehead.

The pain from the wound made Ning Ze’s lips twitch. Snorting coldly, he said: “Luckily, I was finally able to take my hands off this hot potato.

“However, Ning Xiaoren has another task for me. It’s regarding Little Zhuo...”

Ning Ze briefly explained the situation.

When he finished speaking, Wang Lan's eyebrows shot upward, like a cat with its fur standing on end. "What? We have to spend money to help him get into the family industry now?"

"No, I don't agree! How many spirit stones will that cost?"

"We suffered to raise him for so many years, and now we have to spend money on him again?"

Ning Ze sighed. "When he was in the academy, he didn't have to pay tuition. All we really spent on him was a negligible sum for daily expenses. Moreover, his mother left behind some money before her death."

Wang Lan shouted: "Are you out of your mind? That money belongs to us! Back then, when Ning Zhuo's mother was lying on her deathbed, she took my hand and personally gave me the money."

"You were there, and several elders were also present. Ning Zhuo's mother clearly said that the money wasn't for raising Ning Zhuo, but a gift of gratitude to us!"

"That money is ours. We can use it however we want."

Ning Ze sneered: "Correct, but that's exactly why we mustn't treat Little Zhuo poorly. After all, I am his uncle, and he ranked 31st in the clan examination. I can't not show him some care."

Wang Lan gritted her teeth. Raising her eyebrows, she expressed her disagreement: "If you want to spend such a large sum of money, you'd better kill me first."

"That troublesome little bastard. And that greedy devil Ning Xiaoren! They all deserve to die!"

“Husband, can’t you see? Ning Xiaoren specifically asked you to do this because he wants you to pay him and use his connections to help Ning Zhuo enter the family industry.

“Don’t you know what kind of person he is?

“Ning Xiaoren is fickle and narrow-minded. After making a promise one day, he’ll come up with some excuses the next.

“In the past, we thought that working under him would make our lives easier. But then, whenever we made any requests, he either ignored them or demanded payment.

“Don’t you remember when we asked him for help in acquiring the position of procurement manager? He demanded three times more than others would!

“Now, he just wants to use this matter with Ning Zhuo to cheat us again.

“Hmph, if he truly cared about that life-saving favor, why has he never asked about Ning Zhuo in all these years? If he really wanted to repay the favor, he could directly arrange a spot in the family business for Little Zhuo. After all, he is the junior patriarch.

“Hypocrite! He’s a damn hypocrite!”

Ning Ze sighed: “You think I don’t know this? His meaning is obvious – I didn’t do a good job, so if I don’t take this opportunity to make him happy, he will take away my post as procurement manager!”

Wang Lan was in disbelief: “Husband, are you so spineless? You’ll let him just blackmail our family like this?

“You have your own son to take care of. Ji’er also needs resources to cultivate. What have we given him? We can’t even get him those cakes

from the Golden Restaurant he likes.”

Ning Ze’s expression darkened. “Nonsense! Even the chief steward can’t afford to eat Golden Flake Jade Dew Cakes all the time.

“Don’t worry, let me think this through carefully.”

Ning Ze was extremely reluctant to pay bribes to send Ning Zhuo into the family business. Unlike his wife, Wang Lan, it wasn’t that he was stingy with money; instead, it was due to concerns about face.

Ning Zhuo had only just quarreled stubbornly with them, and now Ning Ze was supposed to run around bribing people for his sake? Where would his dignity as the boy’s elder be?

He would be more like a servant!

Notes:

[^1]: *Ning Zhong* – 寧忠 – *Zhong* means “loyal”.